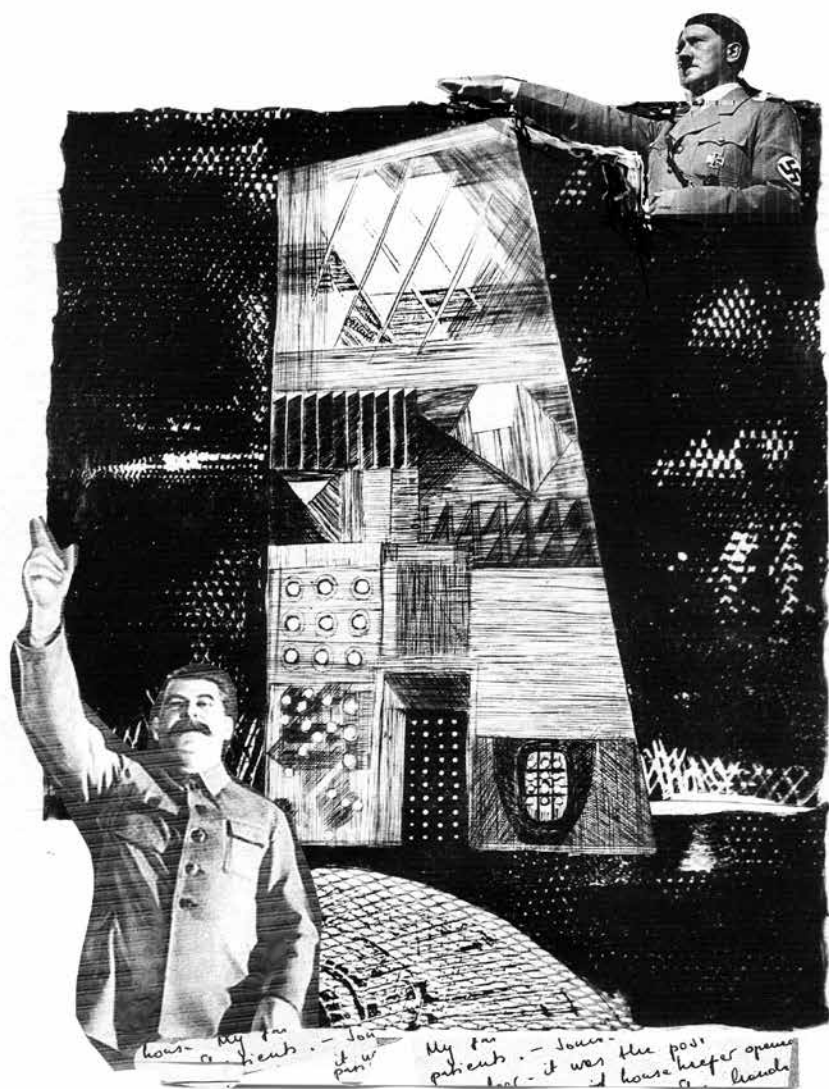




October 1941

7 December 1941

11 December 1941

Establishment of Auschwitz II (Birkenau) for the extermination of Jews; Gypsies, Poles, Russians, and others were also murdered at the camp
 Japanese attack Pearl Harbour
 United States declares war on Japan and Germany

The Holocaust Diaries

The Letter

My diary was assembled from bits of paper in 1945. By then I had missed out on two years of schooling.

Although I read fluently and voraciously, my handwriting was appalling, with large sprawling letters, it was at times hardly legible.

We were liberated by the Russian army on the 13th February 1945

Our survival was nothing short of a miracle.

My diary started on the 15th March 1943. It starts with the title *'The Physician of the State'*

I was with my father that day in Liszt Ferenc Tér 4. This was a weekly arrangement, a treat, when I could go for long walks with my father and Csumi, his singing dachshund. She would leap high into the air to fetch her lead. Whilst we were walking, my father would tell me stories and talk to me like an adult.

Giza our housekeeper brought in a registered letter to be signed for.

It said that the government wanted my father to go to Öcseny, a small village about 60 kilometres from Budapest, to take up the post of country doctor as the local doctor had been called up for military service. This had been arranged by my godfather who was a general in Admiral Horthy's army and belonged to his inner circle. He had the intention of saving us from persecution. After the receipt of the registered letter, my father took me home and told my mother that he would have to leave the next day and we should follow as soon as practical by train, taking as little luggage as possible. Before we left, they somehow managed to find time to remarry, allowing us all to travel with him.

He also explained that we would have to wear a yellow star as our family was of Jewish origin. I remember he said this was something to be proud of, that Jews were a very cultured people with many leading scientists, artists, poets and entrepreneurs among them, that they were the mainstay of society, a nonviolent peace-loving people.

After my father's departure, we heard the air raid warnings three

times a day and we had to go down to the cellar. The allied bombing had started in earnest and whole streets were demolished. Hundreds of people were killed as few houses had shelters and the government was totally unprepared.

When there was a lull in the bombing, we left our apartment in the care of our maid Elsa and got a taxi to the railway station and took the train to Öcsény.

Öcsény

We lived for a couple of months in the doctor's house. It was a basic, unremarkable but clean house with a surgery. My father received lots of patients from the village. He had to go over his basic training and attend to births, deaths, broken limbs and all other problems occurring in general practice, none of which he was used to in his practice as a consultant neurologist.

He learnt fast and improvised often as few traditional medicines were available and even bandages were in short supply. The villagers were extremely grateful and appreciative, but more often than not paid with eggs, chicken or other farm produce. They had little or no money.

On a beautiful dewy morning, I went out to the common and there was the goose girl, who looked after little goslings.

She was a hefty peasant girl of about 16. I found her sitting in the grass with some of her goslings in her apron. In my art collection, I now have a photograph of a much younger goose girl which was taken by the famous Hungarian photographer André Kertész whom I was to meet many years later and who, it turned out, came from the same village as my husband.

The goose girl started mocking me for being a Jew, singing insulting little ditties. I became furious and started hitting her, but was no match for a strong 16-year old. I was badly beaten and totally demoralised. I heard that in other villages Jewish children were often abused and pelted with stones, and adults were also beaten up.

My mother and I visited the local school one day with the intention of assessing it, in case I wanted to continue my education there. The children were divided into two or three groups and had to learn their tables by rote. If they got it wrong, they got beaten with a cane, mostly on the nails, where it hurts most. I was utterly shocked by this treatment and lack of sensibility and decided not to go.

My father went out to buy the newspapers and listened to the radio. He heard about the anti-Jew laws coming into effect, initiated by Adolf Eichmann¹⁹ and enforced by Ferenc Szálasi²⁰.



for military service
 One heard odd rumours on
 The Germans are here - dispersed people
 from east to care - Maybe in an hour
 five street fights would take place
 - day I was in dirt fence house
 that, who took me home



The physician of the state
Departure
 It was the 15th of March 1940
 My father was consulting his
 patients - Someone knocked at
 the door - it was the postman.
 Gira, the housekeeper opened
 and took the letter. She handed
 it to my father, who said
 communicated with his patients;
 he has to leave, the state phi-
 him to Dying is. Village phi-
 The old one was called up
 for military service.
 One heard odd rumours that day
 The Germans are here - dispersed people
 from east to care - Maybe in an hour
 five street fights would take place
 - day I was in dirt fence house
 that, who took me home



The laws required Jews to go and live in ghettos or houses marked with the yellow star, the windows which looked onto the street had to be blocked out. They could not go into parks, use public transport, or go into the street after dark. If they were caught defying these rules or not wearing the yellow star, they were killed or transported to extermination camps to be gassed or murdered in other ways.

My parents did not want to worry me and spoke German. Little did they know that Elsa had taught me some German and so I could understand these hushed snippets of conversation. **(Parts of films to be included with a link from a specially created website)**

Persecution

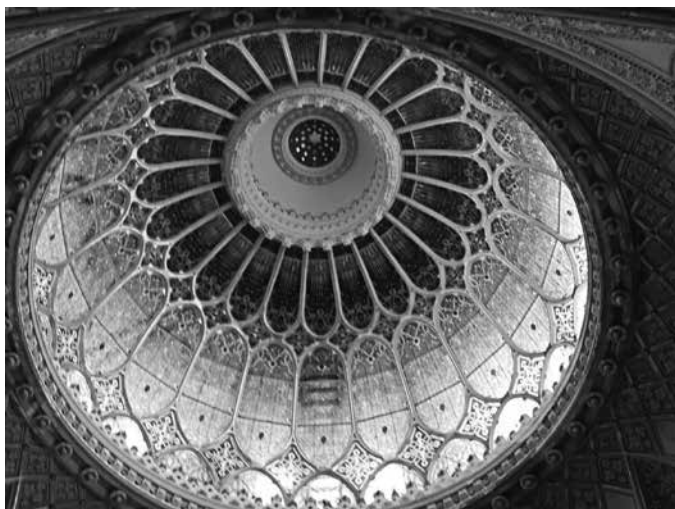
In the meantime, Jews all over the country were trying to get false papers and assume fake identities. This cost a lot of money, and not everyone could afford them. Some converted to Christianity to protect themselves from persecution. Unlike the Jesuits, the priests of other orders were not always helpful and denied assistance or shelter to desperate people.

There is a vivid description of a situation like this in Janos Nyiri's²¹ autobiographical novel *Battlefields and Playgrounds* when a Protestant priest would not even let his mother and him, then a small boy, into the church when they were totally exhausted and destitute. We heard that our friend Dr. Gabor, had to move daily with his family from one ex-patient to another, to shelter for a day or two in their attic or cellar and then be asked to move on, because the patients no longer dared to take the responsibility for harbouring them. They could be shot on the spot by the Arrow Cross²² thugs trained and encouraged by Szálasi if they were found out. So, they wandered on for weeks with their two children, not knowing where they were going to sleep that night. It happened one time

19 Adolf Eichmann (1906-1962) was one of the main organisers of the Holocaust

20 Ferenc Szálasi (1897-1946), the leader of the fascist Arrow Cross Party – Hungarist Movement acted as both Head of State and Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Hungary's "Government of National Unity" (Nemzeti Összefogás Kormány) for the final six months of Hungary's participation in World War II. He assisted the Germans with deporting Hungary's Jews and after the war, he was executed for war crimes and crimes against humanity

21 Janos Nyiri (1932-2002) was a Hungarian Holocaust Survivor whose novel *Battlefields and Playgrounds* (Macmillan, London, 1990) has been described as the most important novel about the Holocaust



The stained glass window of the synagogue in Szeged

that a patient, whose life the doctor had saved several times, put them up in the loft but had to ask them to leave suddenly in the middle of the night. Her Arrow Cross son arrived home unexpectedly and suspected something. They stealthily crossed the back garden only to find iron railing impeding the way. The slimmer members of the family could squeeze through, but the father could not. The 12-year old son, Ervin, by using all his force, managed to bend an iron bar so his father could push through and lower himself to the street, all in the pelting rain. The smaller boy was only four years old. They were not out of danger yet as Jews were not allowed in the streets after dusk. Other Jewish doctors were assembled in the brick factory outside Budapest, where they worked breaking stones for road construction. They were later murdered, their bodies left in the mud until the end of the war.

Eva, Sanyi's niece, and her father were picked up on the streets of Budapest and were murdered in the gas chambers. The photographers Béla Kálman and Imre Weisz, husband of artist Leonora Carrington, were taken to labour camps but were among the few who escaped.

22 The Arrow Cross Party-Hungarist Movement was the Fascist party that led Hungary for the final six months of the war, so known because of its flag which depicts arrows made into the form of a cross. This was an ancient symbol of the Magyar tribes who settled Hungary, thereby suggesting the racial purity of the Hungarians. It also bore a striking resemblance to the Nazi swastika

The final solution was worked out systematically and six million Jews were murdered, 10,000 a day. Few escaped. This was, it seems, acceptable, even popular in Germany and Austria as the disenfranchised and jobless poor craved revenge after the deprivations and losses of World War I.

It is possible that few knew precisely what was happening, although there were eye witness accounts at the 1942 pogroms in Poland, which was typical:

The war was already coming to an end and the German army was withdrawing.

The Warsaw ghetto was being “cleared up” and the men were taken away to labour camps. Only women, children, the old and disabled remained and the SS received the order to kill them.

The unit had 650 soldiers and the commander gave the option to his men to shoot or step aside. Only 15 withdrew. This happened in other locations as well. The excuse that people “only followed orders” was simply not true.

A question I have often asked myself is how much did my parents know about what was happening in Europe? How was it that people were so much in denial of these facts in Hungary and hardly any resistance was organised?

Could they have joined forces and asked for help from the allies? The doctors and other intellectuals were too busy with their professional lives and thought that they were too important to the country and that these atrocities simply could not happen. They had little contact with ordinary people except for their patients and had neither time nor experience to plan any kind of resistance. Also in Hungary, they had little or no support from the local population.

Deportation

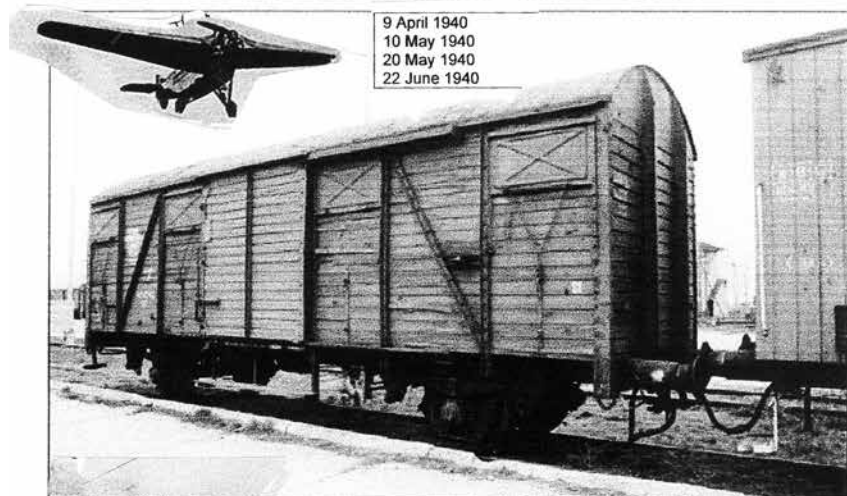
One day, we were taken by bus to a temporary collection centre in the nearby town of Szeged. We took a few belongings and a bit of food in a rucksack, my father took his large medical bag and I carried a demijohn with nine litres of water, which turned out to be a life saver.

Whilst we were in transit, I overheard a conversation in German. My father told my mother that he had morphine in his medical bag; If the worst came to the worst, he would rather kill us all, than allow us to be taken to the gas chambers.

Did he not know that women and children were separated from their male relatives? They were first shaved, tattooed on their arms with a number. From then on, inmates were not allowed to use their names, just the numbers to humiliate them and rob them of



Jews wearing the star emblem, arrive in Auschwitz, in German occupied Poland in June 1944



9 April 1940
10 May 1940
20 May 1940
22 June 1940

A freight car, used used to transport Jews, gypsies and other political prisoners to concentration camps, where many were killed

their humanity. They were called “stück”, pieces or items by the German militia.

They took all their clothes, shaved their heads and took them to the showers. When the atmosphere was hot enough and the building steamy, they threw some chemical crystals in through an opening, which transformed into lethal gas. A stampede followed as the choking masses trampled the children and the weakest underfoot. The gas first blinded the victims, and then vomiting and internal bleeding finished them off. It lasted in average 20 minutes. When all was over, the doors were opened and other inmates forced to clear up, to take the corpses to be cremated and buried in mass graves after taking their teeth, hair and sometimes flesh for other uses.

In some of the huts, where bunk beds were occupied by pairs of inmates squeezed together, infectious diseases spread. Constant hunger forced the inmates to steal even from their neighbours. In their weakened state, they still had to report for work; otherwise they would be instantly executed.

How did man sink to such inhumanity towards other human beings? How much of this did my parents know when we arrived to the collection camp in Szeged?

We were taken to an old synagogue near the station, a beautiful brick building with an office and hospital wing in front and a stable yard at the back.

First the women and children were separated from the men and were taken to the hospital wing to be interrogated by the SS. The women were strip searched by nurses who even checked their body cavities to see if they had hidden any valuables or documents there. My mother was searched in my presence. I do not know what they did to the men.

I heard loud screams from women who were tortured with live electrical wires, who staggered out with bruised and swollen limbs.

After the first humiliating experience, they wanted to further interrogate my mother and as I was getting rather distressed, they briefly let me out into the sunny stable yard, where in a cobbled enclosure I saw a curved white wall of a building. In front of it, on the ground, bits of charcoal lay scattered around.

I took up one of these pieces and started drawing three larger than life nude girls on the white wall, representing my two best friends and myself. I was no doubt influenced by the scenes I had just witnessed. Nevertheless, I was proud of this act of defiance proving that one does not need expensive materials, art is in the mind.

Shortly afterwards, we were all herded into the synagogue, men

Hidden in the Torah Ark in the Szeged Synagogue

Establishment of Auschwitz II (Birkenau) for the extermination of Jews, Gypsies, Poles, Russians, and others were also murdered at the camp



and women together and they locked and bolted the door.

There were several hundred people from all over Hungary; doctors, engineers, musicians, some were much better informed than us. They thought that we were going to be gassed right there. They frantically started to break the stained-glass windows to get air in. I was hidden in the Aron Hakodesh, the Holy Ark where the Torah is kept, where I slept all night, hardly aware of the sanctity of the place.

The Cattle Trucks

Nothing happened in the night, but in the morning, we were marched to the nearby railway station and pushed and crammed into the waiting cattle trucks. The doors were slammed shut. There were so many people that only a few could sit down on the floor or on their luggage, the others had to stand pressed together. A bucket was placed in the corner, so that, screened by a sheet, people could relieve themselves. The buckets soon filled up but when people tried to empty them, they were shot at.

There was a narrow opening on the top of the carriage though we could see a bit of the sky and the name of the stations as we passed through. We worked out that we were going north.

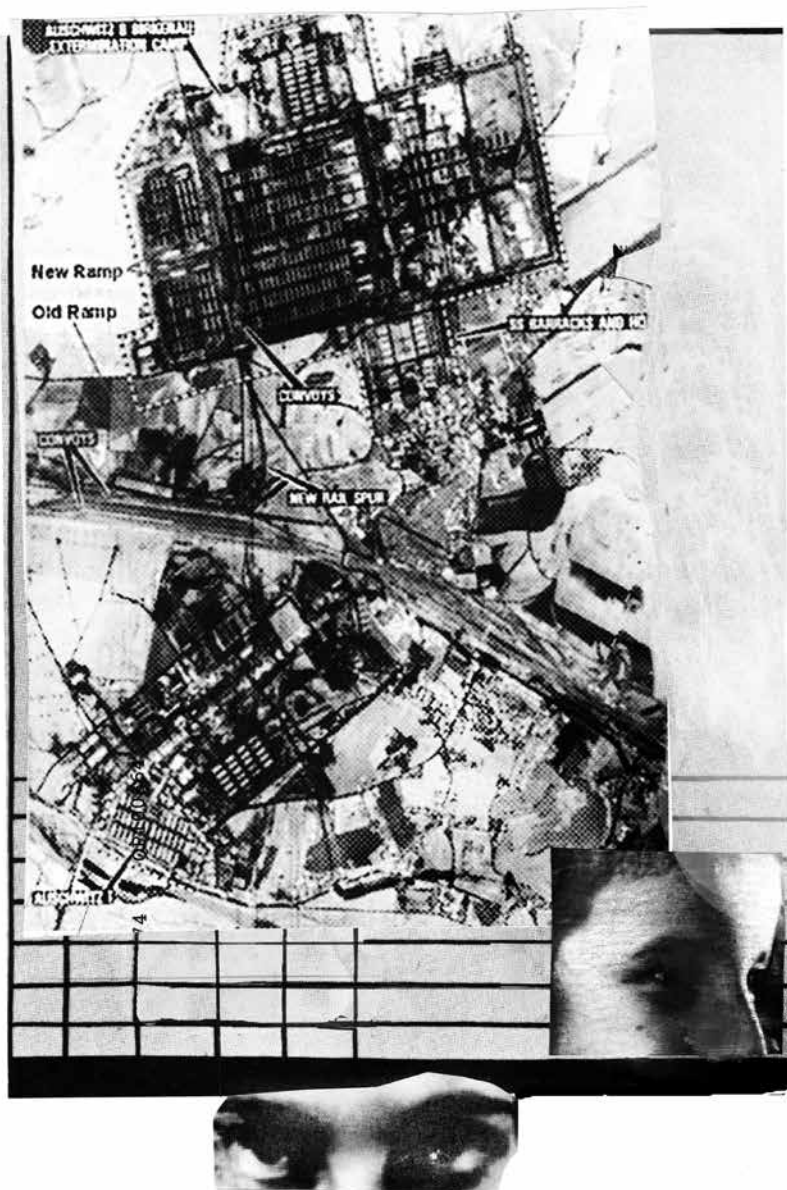
A few women still clung onto their handbags and high heeled shoes. They tried to find cosmetics and perfume to lessen the stench emanating from the buckets. They would soon be denied these remnants of civilisation.

The train went extremely slowly and sometimes stopped for hours on end. People were getting really tired of standing up and started to change places to rest their legs a bit. Commands were heard from outside and bullets were fired. We heard the guards trying to get money or possessions from those on board, saying that where we were going, there would be no use for these.

<https://youtu.be/Eeig3urmwas> Holocaust film Son of Saul

It was getting dark and the train was shunted from one line to another several times with a lot of clanking and screeching and braking. Then the sky lit up and we saw airplanes. Those in the know said they were British and that they were bombing the rails in front of us. We could see what amounted to a firework show through our narrow opening and it was absolutely spectacular. Strangely, nobody panicked; we felt absolutely safe. These bombers knew what they were doing. A couple of hours passed and our guards must have been in telephone contact with their superiors and it was established that the rails on this stretch were

Aerial view of Auschwitz and Birkenau Concentration camp



ruined and impassable and they would have to vacate the wagons until a solution was found and another route could be established.

We were ordered to get off, take our possessions and were marched up to a prison building nearby which was for prisoners in transit. The building was empty and we were given bread and milk for the children, which was a marvellous treat. We continued to watch the firework spectacular in much more comfortable circumstances and eventually managed to go to sleep on the floor.

Early in the morning we were herded back onto our train, which was shunted several times through different junctions and eventually was redirected to a line leading to the capital, Budapest.

At the railway station, we were let off and were met by representatives of the International Red Cross. Unknown to us Raoul Wallenberg²³, the Swedish diplomat had made a bargain with the SS. He was there at the railway station and organised our destinations from there.

I am sure a substantial sum of money was involved. The adults were taken to a house near the Danube, which was protected by the Red Cross and the children to a rather gracious villa on the other side of the Danube. This villa was made available by Elemer Somfay, a famous Olympic pentathlon champion of impeccable Aryan credentials and transformed into a school, with Catholic nuns in their white coifs and black habits in charge of the children's education.

There were about 20 beds in a room with hardly any space between and the classroom had a blackboard, but no chairs, so we all had to sit on the floor. Somewhere they found a grand piano in the house, which made an impression at the assembly.

Two of three weeks later, there was a noise at the door and two fully armed SS soldiers marched in. They quickly realized what was going on and said they would return soon.

There was utter panic amongst the nuns; it was evident, that we had been denounced. The school had to be vacated at once! The nuns hurriedly phoned the Red Cross and presumably Wallenberg, who got in touch with the parents whom he had placed in the protected house. We children had to be removed at once!

I was one of the last to leave, but my parents eventually managed

²³ Raoul Wallenberg 1912-c.1947 was a Swedish diplomat who saved tens of thousands of Hungarian Jews during the Holocaust by issuing them with protective passports and sheltering them in buildings that were designated as Swedish territory. He disappeared during the Siege of Budapest by the Red Army, and is presumed to have been murdered by the Russians
See <http://www.raoulwallenberg.net> for further information



**Bronze shoe memorial
at the Danube**

to get in touch with our maid Elsa, who as a Bavarian, a German national, would not be stopped if she walked with a child through the streets.

We reached the bridgehead in a few minutes but found a couple of armed SS men blocking the entrance. However, as they did not physically stop us, we just ignored them and started walking speedily across the bridge. It was an eerie experience as the bridge was by then quite empty. There were two mean looking guards on the other side, fully armed and closing off the entrance to the bridge.

About two minutes after we crossed, there was a hell of an explosion; the earth shook. A cloud of dust emerged and the bridge was no more, just the tangled remains could hardly be seen.

Elsa and I hurried to the “protected house” where I jumped into the arms of my parents, who were extremely worried. I myself had thought I might never see them again.

Many families were crammed into two floors. We recognized people from the train, but others were unfamiliar. We had a divan bed for the three of us, but others had to lie on the floor and in the corridors.

About two days passed. There was water, but very little food. Then the tables were turned again. A couple of Arrow Cross youths, not more than 14-15 years old, entered the house with rifles slung over their shoulders. These slum kids were specially trained and armed by Szálasi, who was still hell bent on completing the roundup of the Jews.

The Arrow Cross boys selected a few people from our house and marched them down to the Danube. They were told to take their shoes off and then they were shot into the river. The boys came back several times to continue with their murderous task. They were obviously enjoying it.

Shoes cast in bronze can now be found by the riverside where the shootings took place as a memorial and reminder of these atrocities.

I was hidden in the bedding compartment of the couch so no-one would notice me; strangely I was sure that as long I was with my parents, nothing terrible would happen. Finally, somebody got in touch with Wallenberg, who came over himself with armed Swedish guards from the embassy and we were escorted to the part of the town where buildings had been converted into stylish apartments, rather lavish middle-class homes. I understand substantial amounts of money were offered to the government for releasing the Jews. This money might have come from Wallenberg himself, who came from an extremely rich banking family, but most likely from American or British Jews, who felt guilty for not doing more for their people. Wallenberg, who was fearless and took a great many risks, was eventually captured by the Russians who accused him of spying. It is now confirmed that they tortured and killed him in the Lubianka prison. Life in Stalin's Russia almost rivalled Nazi Germany in its cruelty and inhumanity.

This was nearly the end of the war for Hungary. The Russian army was already on the outskirts of Budapest completing a pincer movement to encircle the capital and the Germans. The Germans wanted to make it as hard as possible for the Russian army to advance while they were withdrawing towards Berlin and blew up all bridges and crossings.

The Ghetto

We were conducted by Wallenberg and a few uniformed Swedish guards from the unsafe building of the Red Cross to an apartment block. The original inhabitants were away and the apartments stood in ghostly emptiness, fully equipped with fridges, clothes, schoolbooks, toys and musical instruments. The owners had in all probability been taken away and murdered. We started relaxing a little bit, began cooking and my mother decided to wash herself and the clothes she was wearing in a basin. There was actually hot water, a rare luxury that she had been unable to enjoy for a long time. She had stripped down to the waist when the building suffered a hit from a bomb or missile and the chimney was blown away, just as some of the new inhabitants had been trying to fire up the boilers. My mother got completely covered with soot and, although it seemed very funny at the time, it was days before she could get cleaned up properly using different oils, soap and alcohol.

A few days passed, before we realized that all was quiet outside, the SS had left and the Russian army was in command, patrolling the streets with tanks and by foot.

We ventured out to the streets and found most buildings ruined, broken glass everywhere. The dead were lying on the ground or had been hastily buried in front gardens of public buildings. I remember seeing a ghostly arm sticking out of the ground in front of a familiar landmark.

Finally, we reached my mother's apartment house in Ferenc Kőrut, where we found my grandmother and Moci Papa rather short of food, but in relatively good health, being looked after by our maid Elsa. My father went to his flat in Liszt Ferenc tér, 4 where he found things almost as he left, being looked after by his faithful housekeeper Giza. This was not a common experience as Jewish properties were allocated to others or taken over by strangers; the contents looted or sold off. Neither was this the happy end of the story.

End of War, the Soviet Occupation

The Russian troops were relatively friendly; and we had no doubt, that they saved our lives.

These simple peasant boys suffered great deprivations and losses during the War. Millions of their family and friends were killed by the Germans or simply died of cold or starvation. They loved children and they loved music. They sometimes gave us food and played the balalaika when they were relaxing in the evening.

Of course, some were undisciplined and looted, raped and requisitioned. They stopped people in the street and took off their watches which they strapped right up to their armpits. They collected all kinds of luxuries which were unavailable in the USSR. Train loads of fridges, washing machines and other valuables were transported back to Russia. We did not blame them, but worse was to come.

They also took people, some, who just escaped from the concentration camps or forced labour camps and transported them back to the USSR to work in Siberia in the Gulags²⁴. They were forced to work in inhuman conditions. Some came back ghosts of their former selves after seven years; most never came back.

My aunt Klári, who was now living in Canada, used to send us regular food parcels and warm clothes through this period. I have a letter written by my mother to her during the winter months of 1945, fairly soon after the siege of Budapest. There is no exact date on this letter, but it does mention the fact that currency has very little value and describes the bartering for food and lack of fuel and that school has already started for children. At the close of the letter, my mother thanks her for everything she sent us. She also sent her a poem I had written which I have translated and include here.

My dearest Klári,

Goti came home from school today with this poem all worked out in her head. I would have preferred her to write it down herself, but she has both English and piano lessons and will not have time to do so before the weekend. As I am so late with my answer to you I will do it myself.

The Sun and the Moon.

We can see the sun early in the morning

First a narrow strip of light

It's still like a frightened little bird

Hesitating to leave the nest.

Then it grows more and more

Spreading its generous rays,

Striking woods pastures and meadows

Willing to look into the smallest hovels,

Calling animals and humans into life

If only he could always stay the king of the skies!

²⁴ Gulag is an acronym for the Russian term Main Administration of Camps and was the government agency in charge of the forced labour camp system that was created in the Soviet Union under Lenin and reached its peak during Stalin's dictatorship

Wherever he goes buds are burgeoning
Ripe fruits are smiling back at him,
Where he goes sorrow or grief disappear
Hugs everything to its warm rays,
And proceeds to cure all maladies.
If only he could always stay the king of the skies.
After dusk, the darkness makes him flee
Our benefactor exits with a bloodied head
And sinks down into his retreat,
Night creeps up instead.
With stars appearing in its place
Like tiny lanterns in the sky.
Up comes the bright moon,
The skies bow to his dominance
He steps onto his shiny throne
Throwing his dark cape onto the world,
So that only he should shine and
Everyone else should pay homage.
How bright is he and how cold,
As he loves no one but himself
If the sick and the poor have no warm bed
What does he care, the lord of the stars?

A government was formed, which, after the first free elections, became dominated by the Communist Party and the terrifying rule of the General Secretary Mátyás Rákosi²⁵. He nationalized most industries, killed or imprisoned the kulaks, the larger land owners and forced smallholders and landless peasants into collective farms on the Russian Kolkhoz model.

These farms were hopelessly inefficient and serious shortages of food became common.

It was the black market, which revived the economy, to an extent, and most of the ruined buildings and bridges were rebuilt in record time. Food appeared in unrestricted quantities, as long as one could pay for it, not necessarily with money, which has lost its value, but with valuables, such as jewellery, clothes, shoes, and even blankets.

I was quite surprised, when I arrived to England in 1956, that many buildings were still in ruins after the Blitz and that food rationing has only just ended.

²⁵ Rákosi (1892-1971) was Jewish himself, born Matyas Rosenfeld. He became Stalin's most ardent follower and removed many of his political opponents with Stalinist inspired purges